

Chapter 9. Banknote Figures, Common Sense, Tactics and Momentum, Concepts, Opportunity Costs in Politics, Ministers and Slaves, Dream of the Red Chamber

1, Chinese Political Jokes That Are Even Funnier Than Soviet Political Jokes

When I returned to settle down in my familiar city after a four-year absence, I felt even more profoundly that the country had changed drastically. Or perhaps, it had never changed at all; it was merely regressing from the rare openness and freedom at the beginning of the century back to China's inherent "normality" (常态).

The barricades that became ubiquitous during the pandemic on the Giant Wild Goose Pagoda (大雁塔) square—a place I had walked across over a thousand times during my youth and young adulthood—were not removed after the pandemic ended. On the contrary, by 2024, the entire square had been barricaded even more thoroughly!

In the past, people could enter the scenic area unhindered from any direction, making it highly convenient for nearby residents to pass through. But now, entry and exit for the entire Giant Wild Goose Pagoda scenic area are restricted to an exceedingly few designated points; everywhere else is blocked by iron fences. If you attempt to climb over, you risk being intercepted by staff.

Even more absurdly, the direction of pedestrian flow is strictly controlled. Where you exit and where you enter must entirely conform to official arrangements. This kind of physical control is not confined to the interior of the scenic area but extends even to its periphery. In 2024, on three separate occasions when I attempted to pass from east to west along the outer perimeter, I encountered security personnel attempting to block me and funnel me into the scenic area—though I forcefully barged through all three times.

To me, this is utterly inexplicable. Indeed, during holiday evenings, the pedestrian volume between Yanta North Road and Yanta South Road is massive; at those specific times, conducting crowd diversion and control is beyond reproach. However, no one can deny that for the vast majority of the time, there is fundamentally zero necessity for such blockades and controls. **This is nothing but manufacturing endless trouble for the commoners solely for the convenience of the bureaucrats in charge.**

Another phenomenon indicating that this society has become even more oppressive is the subway. Subway security checks (地铁安检) in China are inherently a highly controversial public security issue, which I will not even delve into here.

Starting from the pandemic era, various maze-like barricades began proliferating, forcing residents wishing to enter the subway to detour long distances and inevitably causing congestion. If justified under the pretext of epidemic prevention, this could at least be somewhat explained. Yet, observing the situation of the Xi'an subway in the year and a half since the pandemic ended, these barricades have not diminished; rather, they have multiplied! Ultimately, even during time slots when the subway is practically empty, they are never removed, and when there are large crowds, they paradoxically exacerbate the congestion.

Most ridiculously, I have seen foreign tourists looking utterly helpless multiple times at the Giant Wild Goose Pagoda North Square station when facing these labyrinthine fences, having absolutely no idea how to enter or exit the station.

These inexplicable restrictions made my friends and me feel that our civil rights had been blatantly violated. Some people refer to these barricades as "**livestock pens**" (畜栏), forcing the people to move along rigidly dictated routes exactly like cattle on a farm. In truth, in the eyes of Chinese officials, the people are indeed an entirely different biological species from themselves.

I am now even more certain of one absolute rule in a **bureaucratic state: one must absolutely never expect the government to automatically relinquish its power after expanding it under various pretexts, because there are absolutely no methods to supervise or restrict it!**

From another perspective, our country's political propaganda has become even more shameless. Although it has *always* been shameless, it at least exercised some restraint during the period of favorable economic conditions at the beginning of the century. Now, as the economic situation deteriorates by the day, the contempt and hostility toward the people within official news broadcasts have become increasingly unvarnished.

For example, the issue of self-built housing fires and collapses is incredibly severe in our country. The January 10, 2024, episode of *Focus Report* (《焦点访谈》) specifically addressed the safety hazards of self-built housing, focusing heavily on a building collapse incident in April 2022 that resulted in dozens of deaths.

What infuriated me to my core was this: is it possible that the people renting self-built houses are unaware that they are unsafe? But *why* must they brave such risks to rent these dwellings? Today, China's industrial capacity is by no means weak, and the construction industry is hardly some highly sophisticated, cutting-edge sector. If the entire nation truly possessed "*tens of thousands of spacious mansions to bring joy to all the commoners across the realm*" (有广厦千万间，令天下百姓俱欢颜), who on earth would risk their lives to rent dangerous slums?

Throughout the entire broadcast, one could not witness a single trace of genuinely meaningful reflection. It was entirely composed of leaders feigning heartbreak, swearing oaths that they would rigorously investigate and crack down in the future, vowing never to leave any room for self-built housing to exist.

The entire program first shirked the responsibility entirely onto the people, portraying the people as ignorant, foolish, and greedy for petty gains (贪利); whatever tiny shred of responsibility remained was tossed to local low-level officials.

In truth, anyone with a conscience will never forget: **what drives the people to such desperate straits are the astronomically high housing prices manufactured by the entire state, which suffocate society—while the entity hopelessly addicted to land finance (土地财政) is the government itself!**

For the official channel of a nation playing a major role on the world stage to broadcast such an anti-human program during prime time is appalling. Even though I never subscribed to the official viewpoints to begin with, as a Chinese person, I still felt a profound sense of shame.

Back in antiquity, the philosopher Mencius said to King Hui of Liang: *"If Your Majesty ceases to blame the harvest (the heavens) for the starvation of the people, then the people of the world will flock to you"* (王无罪岁，斯天下之民至矣).

But what Mencius could never have foreseen is that King Hui blaming an unobservable and unaccountable "Heaven" actually constituted a form of moral virtue! Even King Hui of Liang, a failed monarch during an era of "collapsing rites and decaying music" (礼崩乐坏), never once in his life uttered words to the effect that *"the people brought it upon themselves."*

But now? **Those in power can brazenly and righteously declare that the commoners deserve their suffering!**

Even more tragically, it seems there are always individuals eager to prove this exact point through their own actions.

During the winter break in early 2022, nearly a year before China would finally lift its pandemic lockdowns, my mother and I were returning to her workplace via public bus after an outing in the northern suburbs of Xi'an. As luck would have it, while I was rushing for the bus, the mask in my pocket fell out, a fact I didn't realize until I had already boarded.

The bus driver repeatedly urged me to find my mask. After the bus had driven past two stops, I finally confirmed that it was indeed lost. By then, several minutes had passed, and we were only two or three stops away from our destination anyway.

However, the driver and the other passengers adamantly refused to let a "dangerous subversive" (危险分子) who had lost his mask remain on the bus. Ultimately, my mother and I were kicked off halfway to our destination. *(To his credit, the driver did conscientiously pull over near some storefronts, as the probability of finding a place selling masks was at least slightly higher there).**

This incident left an extraordinarily profound impression on me. **Our society is indeed exactly like this: it never hesitates to exhibit unreserved malice toward those it can bully, yet treats the lies of those in power as sacred imperial edicts to be blindly obeyed.**

In this ludicrous and tragic environment, the segment of Chinese people whose minds remain clear have created an abundance of "Chinese political jokes," naturally inheriting the fine tradition of our Big Brother's "Soviet political jokes."

Though calling them strictly "political jokes" is somewhat inaccurate—many are simply "jokes of daily life"—their satire is exquisitely ingenious. Even the most brilliant chapters of *A New Account of the Tales of the World* (《世说新语》 / *A classic Chinese text of historical anecdotes*) might not match them.

I will recount three highly classic "Chinese jokes" here, though naturally, they can only be truly understood by residents of the East Asian cultural sphere.

The First Joke:

Question: Our country constantly proclaims that we are "crossing the river by feeling the stones" (摸着石头过河), but why do I feel that hope is becoming increasingly bleak?

Answer: Because the river we are crossing by feeling the stones is the **Sanzu River** (三途川 / **The River of the Underworld/Styx**)!

The Second Joke directly parodies a famous passage from the *Zuo Zhuan* (《左传》 / *The Commentary of Zuo*):

"The emperor makes sagacious judgments, and the bureaucrats govern the peace; this is the system of today. Within the fenced borders, what is not the sovereign's land? Eating the produce of the soil, who is not the sovereign's subject? Therefore, the "Constitution" states: "Under the vast heaven, there is no land that is not the king's; to the very borders of the land, there is no one who is not **consumable material** (耗材 / **cannon fodder/expendables**)."

There are ten suns in the sky, and humans are divided into ten castes. The inferiors serve the superiors, and the superiors enjoy the luxuries. Thus: The Foreigners rule the Japanese; the Japanese rule the Taiwanese; the Taiwanese rule the Hong Kongers; the Hong Kongers rule the Overseas Chinese; the Overseas Chinese rule the Beijingers; the Beijingers rule the Shanghainese; the Shanghainese rule the Ethnic Minorities; and the Ethnic Minorities rule the Han Chinese (汉族).

(Note: This meticulously outlines the perceived, albeit utterly twisted, social discrimination chain in modern China).

People are meant to be controlled, and speech is meant to be censored, so as to handle all worldly affairs.

The Third Joke:

During the celebration of the 73rd anniversary of the National Day in 2022, someone posted a common Chinese folk saying: "At 73 and 84, if Yama (the King of Hell) doesn't come for you, you go to him yourself" (73、84，阎王不找自己去).

Unsurprisingly, this person was reported for subversion. However, the person defended himself saying: "The ages of 73 and 84 are thresholds (坎); it means the elderly are prone to passing away at these two ages. This is now our 73rd National Day, which proves our country has safely survived the 73rd year since its founding and overcome a massive threshold! I am clearly celebrating the Motherland's birthday; why are you criticizing me?"

Jokes like these are constantly manufactured on the internet, only to be censored and deleted by auditors within hours. But precisely because such jokes are so intimately tied to people's daily lives, it is impossible to delete them all. I firmly believe that the Chinese jokes created on the Chinese internet between 2019 and 2024 have far surpassed those of the former Soviet Union in both quality and quantity.

Even more prevalent than such satire is **deconstruction** (解构).

Thanks to the modern internet, it is far easier for Chinese netizens to deconstruct a "sacred" concept than ever before. Even if you have no other skills, you only need to do one thing to achieve this goal: **repetition—a thousand times over**.

For example, faced with the phenomenon of "cyber Red Guards" (网络红卫兵) constantly using Mao Zedong's quotations to attack others, these very quotations are increasingly being deployed in completely opposite, or even downright nonsensical (无厘头), contexts. By 2024, even when logging onto a gaming forum, you frequently encounter hilarious comments parodying Mao's famous speeches: "I am not afraid of [X Game Mechanic] at all; whenever I hear about [X], I get happy..."

Therefore, I must say this: although I frequently complain that the cognitive level of the Chinese people has become overwhelmingly degraded under prolonged bureaucratic rule, the partial opening up since the late 1970s has, after all, allowed us to understand a bit of the outside world.

Many among the Chinese commoners now possess their own independent thoughts and judgments. **Attempting to deceive and enslave them is no longer as easy as it was during Mao Zedong's era.**

In our country, resistance is spreading and evolving in this form—seemingly gentle, yet omnipresent, happening at every moment of every day. What I want to express here is that hope does not depend on its size; **its very existence is its greatest significance.**

In the second half of 2023 and the first third of 2024, it was precisely while carrying this profound sensibility toward China's unique social reality that I continued my reflections.

九，纸币人物，常识，术与势，观念，政治中的机会成本，臣和奴才，红楼梦

1，比苏联政治笑话更好笑的我国政治笑话

当我时隔四年再次回到熟悉的城市定居，便更加感到国家已经改变了太多，又或者说它从来也没有什么改变，只不过是世纪初罕见地，相对于中国传统的开放和自由中回归到中国原本的“常态”。我少年和青年时期走过上千次的大雁塔广场上疫情期间变得随处可见的围挡并没有随着疫情而被撤掉，反倒是到了2024年整个广场被围得更彻底了，过去人们可以从任何方位不受阻拦地进入景区，周边居民想要穿过这里十分方便。但是现在整个大雁塔景区的进出就被限制到极少数的位置，其他地方全部都用栅栏挡住，如果翻越的话可能被工作人员阻拦。更离谱的是，人流的方向都会被严格控制，从哪里出到哪里进都必须合乎官方的安排，这种管制不只是存在于景区内部，甚至延伸到了外围。2024年有三次我想从景区外围由东向西通过时都遇到了安保人员试图拦住并将我导入景区内部的情况，不过我三次都强行闯过去了。这在我看来简直是莫名其妙，的确节假日的晚上北到雁塔北路南到雁塔南路之间的景区人流量极大，这个时候进行疏导和管制无可厚非。可是谁也不能否认的是，绝大多数时间根本不存在进行这种封锁和管制的必要，这完全是在给老百姓制造麻烦而让管事的人方便。

同样显示这个社会变得更加压抑的是地铁，地铁安检在中国本身就是一个有争议的公共安全议题，这我都不说了。从疫情期间开始各种栏杆变得越来越多，迫使想要进入地铁的居民要绕很长的距离并且陷入拥堵，这如果说以防疫为理由还可以至少解释一下。可是从西安地铁的情况来看，疫情结束之后的一年半的时间里这种栏杆非但没有变少，反而越变越多，到最后在整个地铁没有什么人的时间段也从来不散，而在人多的时候反倒加剧了拥挤。最为可笑的是，我不止一次在大雁塔北广场站中看到外国游客面对迷宫一样的围栏感到无助，完全不知道该怎么进站或者出站。这种莫名其妙的限制使我和我的朋友感到自己的公民权受到了侵犯，一些人把这些栏杆称之为“畜栏”，迫使人民如同农场的牲口一样沿着规定的路线运动，事实上在中国的官员看来人民的确跟自己就是两个物种。我更加确信在官僚国家绝对不能指望政府以各种理由扩张其权力之后还能自动放弃，因为没有任何监督和限制它的办法。

另一个方向上说，我国的政治宣传变得更加无耻，虽然它一直是这么无耻，但是在本世纪初经济状况良好的时期尚且有所收敛，现在随着经济形势的日益恶化，即便是官方新闻中对于人民的蔑视和敌视都已经变得愈发不加掩饰了。例如自建房火灾和倒塌问题在我国十分严重，2024年1月10日那期《焦点访

谈》节目专门谈到了自建房的不安全，并且着重讲述了在 22 年四月份的一次造成几十人死亡的自建房倒塌事件。令我极为恼怒的是，自建房不安全租的人不可能不知道，但是他们为什么要冒着这种风险也要租住这些房屋？今天中国的工业能力并不弱，建筑业也不是什么多高精尖的行业，如果全国真能够“有广厦千万间，令天下百姓俱欢颜”，请问究竟有谁去冒着危险租住廉租房呢？整个节目里面看不到任何真正有意义的反思，全部都是领导假装痛心疾首的样子，并且赌咒发誓以后一定要严查严打，绝对不能让自建房有任何生长的空间。整个节目首先把责任推给了人民，认为人民是无知、愚蠢和贪利的，剩下一点责任则扔给了地方官员。其实任何一个有良知的人都不会忘记，把人民逼到这个地步的是整个国家高到令社会窒息的房价，而依赖土地财政的则是政府本身。一个在世界上扮演重要角色的国家的官方频道在黄金时间居然放出如此反人类的节目，即使我本来也不认可官方的观点，但是作为中国人仍然感到十分羞耻。当年孟子对魏惠王说，王无罪岁，斯天下之民至矣。可是孟子不曾想到的是，魏王把罪责归咎于一个无法观察更无法追责的上天何尝不是一种德行？即使是魏惠王这样一个“礼崩乐坏”年代的失败者，他一辈子终究也没有说出“人民是咎由自取”这样的话。可是现在呢？掌权者竟然可以堂而皇之地说老百姓活该。

更悲哀的是，似乎总有人要用自己的行动证明这一点。2022 年初寒假的时候，当时中国离疫情解封还有将近一年，我和我妈妈在西安北郊郊游结束后想要坐公交车回到我妈妈的单位，但是好巧不巧我在赶公交的时候兜里的口罩掉了，直到我上车才发现。司机不断地催促我找口罩，但是已经开过两站之后我终于确定口罩确实是掉了，其实那已经过了好几分钟，并且再有两三站我们也就到了目的地。可是司机和其他乘客坚决不愿意我这个丢了口罩的“危险分子”继续待在公交车上，最终我们母子在中途被赶下了车，不过司机倒是十分认真地把车开到了一些店面旁边再停下，因为那里找到卖口罩的地方的几率至少大一些。这件事让我感触极深，我们的社会的确是如此，它从来不惧于向可以欺负的人展示无所保留的恶意，而把那些当权者的谎言却当成圣旨遵行。

在这种可笑又可悲的环境里，头脑尚且清醒的部分中国人创作了很多“中国政治笑话”，这当然是继承了老大哥苏联的“苏联政治笑话”的优良传统。不过实际上说它们是“政治笑话”并不准确，很多不过是“生活笑话”，但是其讽刺极为巧妙，即使是《世说新语》里面最精彩的篇章也未必能及。我在这里列举三个十分经典的“中国笑话”，当然它们只有东亚文化圈中的居民才能懂。

第一个笑话是这么说的，问：我们国家天天宣称自己在摸着石头过河，但是我怎么觉得希望变得越来越渺茫了？答：因为我们摸着石头过的河是三途川。第二个笑话直接改编了《左传》的名篇昭公七年：天子圣裁，官吏治平，今之制也。藩篱之内，何非君土？食土之毛，谁非君臣？故《宪法》曰“普天之内，莫非王土；率土之滨，莫非耗材。”天有十日，人有十等，下所以事上，上所以享乐也。故洋臣倭，倭臣番，番臣台，台臣港，港臣侨，侨臣京，京臣沪，沪臣少，少臣漠。人有管，言有查，以待百事。第三个笑话则是这样说的，2022 年的时候庆祝国庆 73 周年，有人发了一句“73、84，阎王不找自己去”，不出意外被人举报了，但是这个人自己辩解说，所谓 73，84 是坎，指的是老人容易在这两个岁数去世，现在已经是第 73 个国庆节，说明我国平安度过了建国以来的第 73 年，是经过了一个大坎啊，我明明在庆祝祖国的生日，为什么还要批评我呢？

像这样的笑话在互联网上总是不断地被制造出来，然后在几个小时内被审核删掉，不过正是这样的笑话实在是太过贴近人们的生活，所以删是不可能删完的，我认为即使是从 19 年开始到 2024 年为止，中国互联网上所创作的中国笑话，无论从质和量上都已经远胜于曾经的苏联了。比这类讽刺更多的莫过于解构，多亏了现代互联网，中国的网民想要解构一个神圣的概念实在比以前方便太多，即使你什么也不会，只需要做一件事就能达到目的，那就是重复，千百次的重复。比如面对一些网络红卫兵天天拿毛泽东语录攻击别人的现象，这些语录就越来越被用在反面以及可以算得上是无厘头的地方。到 2024 年即使登上

一个游戏论坛，也经常会看到这样让人发笑的评论：我才不怕 XX，一听到 XX 就高兴…因此我也不得不说，虽然我经常会吐槽中国人的认知水平在长期的官僚统治下已经变得极为低劣，但是自 70 年代末以来的部分开放究竟是让我们了解了一些外部的世界，中国的百姓中有很多已经具有自己的思考和判断，想要欺骗他们，奴役他们，已经不可能像毛泽东的时代一样容易了。在我们国家，抗争就是以这种虽然看起来平缓，但又是无处不在，无时无刻不在的形式蔓延并发展着。我在这里想说的是，希望不在于大小，它的存在就是最大的意义。在 2023 年下半年和 2024 年头 1/3 的时间，我就是怀着对中国独特的社会现实的感受继续着我的思考。